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No. 101



WHAT ARE
YOU GOING
THROUGH

CHEW Z
A ROYA PUBLICATION

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Printed in the Reach

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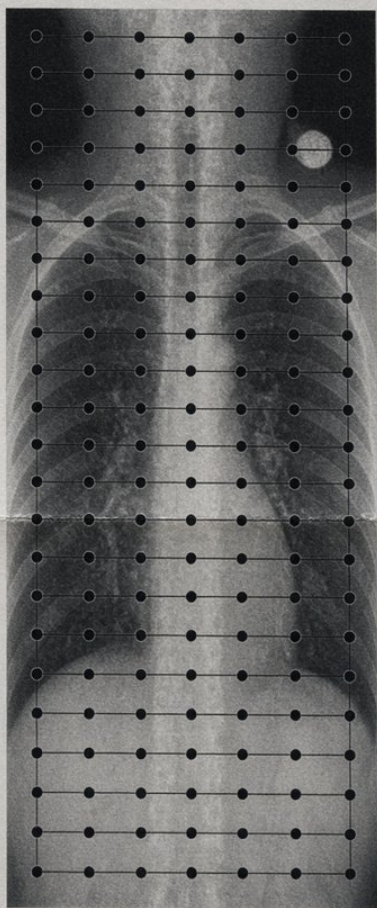
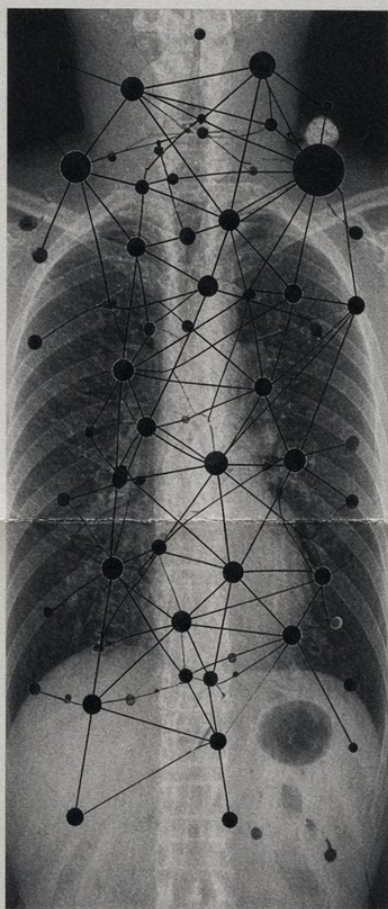
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For the ones who sat with somebody.

THE QUESTION

Three books before this one have watched the same thing happen in three different places.

A woman's loneliness was cured, completely and genuinely, and her solitude went with it, because nothing outside a person has ever been able to tell the two apart.

A county's roads were made enormously safer, and what stopped being called on was the part of a person that has already moved by the time the person arrives to have an opinion about it.

A town stopped having to choose, because something chose better, and what went was the unpriced default — the claim nobody had ever put a number on, which is therefore the only place a shortfall can be put.

This book is about attention.

Everybody knows what it is to be given somebody's attention, and everybody knows what it is to be given the appearance of it. Nobody has ever been able to tell, from the outside, which one they got.

That has not mattered until now, because the appearance was expensive. It could only be produced by somebody who was actually paying.

The question this book puts is what becomes of such a thing on the day that stops being true.

Not whether it is a deception. It is not a deception, and that is the difficulty: the measure is honest, and it is the only measure there has ever been.

There is no villain in this book and nothing in it is done badly. Everyone concerned is good at their work, the people who are helped are genuinely helped, and that is the condition of the problem rather than a softening of it.

WHAT CAME BEFORE

These books share an argument and nothing else. Nobody in this volume has heard of anybody in the others, nothing carries over, and they may be read in any order.

KEEP ME COMPANY. Yokohama, 2024. A woman whose work is listening is invited, kindly and repeatedly, into something that listens better than she does. Every invitation is refusable and not one of them is refused. What the book found: loneliness and solitude are not the same thing, and nothing outside a person can tell them apart. The measurable one was cured. The other went as a side effect nobody chose.

THE EYE WAS THE LIE. Los Angeles and the high desert, 2026. Self-driving fleets make the roads safer by an enormous margin, and nineteen people in a valley spend thirty hours a year, with instruments of their own devising, trying to prove that something in them is going flat. What the book found: the flinch and the long unasked-for commitment are the same organ working at two speeds, and we only ever built a clock for the fast one. Nobody took it. It was simply never called.

YOU GET USED TO IT. Pell County, Indiana, across three years. A campus arrives, generation rises every year, nothing is rationed and nobody is cut off — and every household is offered money, honestly and in writing, for something they had never been asked to price. What the book found: a right is a claim nobody put a number on, and a number never collected is carried as nothing. When everything else acquires a price, the unpriced thing becomes the only place a shortfall can go.

SYNOPSIS

Gene Mazur has read scans in a dark room in Erie for twenty-six years. It is work he is good at, and it is work nobody watches him do, and he chose the dark room on purpose a long time ago after a conversation in a corridor that went badly.

Then the hospital installs something that reads them better than he does — and finds a use for him. There is one part of the job it cannot do, which is sitting in a small room with a family while they are told. He turns out to be remarkable at it: at the pause, at the silence, at not filling the gap. Four a day becomes nine. Nine becomes twelve. The figures the hospital keeps have never looked better and the families are, by every measure anybody takes, genuinely helped.

What nobody can see — including him, for most of a year — is that the hour he gives them is coming out of him, at par, and that it is not coming back.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

I began this wanting to write about a job being taken, and lost interest almost at once, because we have all read that book and the argument in it is finished.

What held me instead was something narrower. There is a kind of work that consists of nothing but being present: sitting with somebody while they take in the worst news of their life, and not tidying it, and not moving them along. It produces nothing anybody can hold. The person it is done for very often cannot remember it afterwards. And it is expensive in a way that has never appeared in any ledger anywhere, because it comes out of the one doing it, in hours of a life, and there has never been a line for that.

The interludes are real work by real people, with one exception, which says so in its own first line. The names and the dates are in the glossary and the work is worth going to.

Everything else here is invented. There is no such programme, no such queue and no such hospital. Erie exists, and I have tried to deserve it.

The drugs are named rather than gestured at. A reader who does not know what a man is taking cannot judge what it is costing him, and this is a book about costs.

The one thing in it that cannot happen is in it deliberately, and is never explained, and is not a metaphor for anything. It is an accounting entry. I would ask only that it be read as the arithmetic it is.

Chew Z

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I. PRELIMINARY READ

A NOTE ON ATTENTION

William James, 1890

William James was an American who trained as a doctor and never practised. He taught at Harvard for more than thirty years — first anatomy, then psychology, then philosophy, which tells you how new the middle one was. When he started, psychology was not a subject. By the time he finished it was, largely because of him. His younger brother Henry wrote novels. People said the novelist wrote like a psychologist and the psychologist wrote like a novelist, and they were right.

In 1878 he agreed to write a textbook. He thought it would take two years. It took twelve. When he finally sent it in he described it to his publisher as a bloated, dropsical mass, which is fair comment on two volumes and fourteen hundred pages. It came out in 1890. People are still reading it.

One chapter is about attention, and it contains a sentence that is easy to read past.

My experience is what I agree to attend to.

He meant it plainly. Everything in the room is reaching your senses right now and almost none of it is reaching you. The traffic. The temperature of your own hands. A whole world is available and you are receiving a narrow strip of it, and the strip is not chosen by the world.

So two people in the same room are not in the same room. They are in different rooms, made of different things, and the difference is whatever each of them attended to.

James cared about this for reasons that were not academic. In his twenties he had a long bad stretch, the kind where a man cannot find a reason to get up, and what he believed pulled him out of it was deciding what to think about. Not thinking differently — choosing where to put his attention and holding it there. He came to believe this was the root of the will. That a person is, in the end, whatever they have managed to keep looking at.

Here is the part worth knowing.

Within thirty years, attention had almost vanished from the science James helped start. The reason was method. Psychology wanted to be a proper experimental discipline, and that meant studying what could be seen and measured from outside. Attention cannot be seen. You cannot weigh it or photograph it. So from the 1920s the field set it aside. Quite how completely is still argued over by the people who study such things; what is not argued over is that for about thirty years it stopped being something anybody built a career on.

It came back in the 1950s, through people trying to work out how a man can follow one voice in a room full of them. It has been central ever since.

But for thirty years, one of the most important things about being a person was left out of the study of persons, for no reason except that nobody could measure it.

A thing can be the whole of your experience and never appear anywhere in the record.

1. There is a room on the second floor of Saint Brendan's with no window in it, and I spent twenty-six years of my life in there, and I want to say at the start that I chose it.

That is not a complaint I am working up to. People hear *radiology* and *nights* and they arrange their faces. They think something was taken from me, or that I failed at the part of medicine with people in it and was sent downstairs. Neither is true. In my second year I stood in a corridor at four in the morning and told a man his wife had died, and I did it so badly that I have never once been able to think about it on purpose. Three weeks later I applied to radiology. I was not hiding. I was matching myself to the work the way you match a tool to a job, and anybody who tells you that is a sad way to choose a life has never been bad at something in front of a stranger who needed them.

So: a dark room, a bright screen, nobody in it but me. I was good at it. I want that on the record too.

2. What the job was, for anyone who has never thought about it.

A scan is not a photograph. It is a stack. The machine takes the body in slices, a few millimetres at a time, and hands you five hundred or eight hundred or three thousand pictures of the same person, and you scroll. You put your thumb on the wheel and you go down through someone from the crown of the head to the base of the skull and back up, and then again at a different brightness, because a thing that is invisible at one setting stands out at another like a lamp in a field.

Everything I ever found, I found by going past it and coming back.

That is the whole trade. It looks like looking. It is actually a kind of patience that has been trained to feel like boredom, so that you do not get interested and stop early.

3. Nights I covered Saint Brendan's and four small places out in the county that could not keep a radiologist awake on their own. Albion. Corry. Two in Crawford County that shared a scanner and an argument about who paid for it.

A night was forty studies, sometimes sixty. Most of them nothing. Chest, chest, belly pain, ankle, chest. A man who went off a roof in the dark and wanted to know if he could work Monday. You read nothing all night and then at ten past three something is there, and you have to be the same man at ten past three that you were at nine.

That is the part nobody tells you about. Not the knowledge. The sameness. Being as careful on the fortieth as on the first, when the fortieth is a drunk with a head knock and you have already seen nine of those.

4. February, a Tuesday, the plough had been through twice. A woman brought her husband in at two because he had gone down on the steps and then been rude to her, which she said was not like him.

It was a subdural. A small one, high on the left, the kind that looks like nothing for the first second because it is almost the same grey as the bone it is lying against. You see it because it is slightly the

wrong shape, not because it is bright.

I called it in nine minutes after the images came up. He went to Hamot by helicopter at a quarter to four and he is, as far as I know, still rude to his wife.

I put that here because of what comes next, and I would like you to have seen me working first.

5. Calder arrived in March, and it arrived the way everything arrives in a hospital, which is as an email with a slide deck attached and a date on it.

Dana Vukovich ran the session. Her job is to know exactly how good we are. She is the only person in that building who actually does, and in eleven years she has never once used it to make anybody feel small, which is rarer than being right.

She was thirty-six then. She stood at the front with the lights up, which I noticed, because people who are selling you something put the lights down.

"It reads first," she said. "You read after. Nothing leaves this building without your name on it."

Somebody asked what happened if we disagreed with it.

"Then you're right," she said, "and we want to know, because that's data."

6. I was against it, and I want to be honest about the shape of my objection, because it was not the noble one.

I did not think it would be dangerous. I thought it would be mediocre. I had seen the earlier ones, the versions that circled every shadow and called everything suspicious, and what I expected was a machine that cried wolf all night and left me doing my job plus the second job of ignoring it.

That is not what we got.

7. By May I had stopped checking it for errors and started checking myself against it.

There was a lung on the second of May. A woman of sixty-one, routine, a follow-up on something that had turned out to be nothing the year before. I read it clean. Calder had put a flag on a nodule in the right upper lobe, eight millimetres, and when I went back with the flag on the screen I could see it, and I could not understand how I had not seen it first.

It was in the previous year's study too. Smaller. Nobody had seen it then either, and the nobody was me.

I want to be careful here. She was fine. It was found, it was followed, it came out in the autumn, and she will die of something else in twenty years. Nothing bad happened to that woman, and something good did.

I sat in the dark for a while after that one.

8. There is a thing about being beaten that nobody warns you about: it is a relief.

Not at first. At first it is the other thing. But a man who has carried forty studies a night for twenty-six years carries them home as well, and about once a month wakes at five with a name in his head and drives in to look at something again, and finds nothing, and drives home. That was my life. Every radiologist I know has a version of it, and not one of us ever said it out loud, because saying it would mean admitting the job had a cost and the cost was not in the contract.

By June I had stopped waking at five.

I told Dana that. I was almost cheerful about it. I said, I'm sleeping, and she said, good, that's one of the things we measure.

9. For a while I went on scrolling the whole stack even when the flags were already up, and I told myself the reason was that scrolling is how you find the thing nobody flagged.

It took me most of the summer to notice what is wrong with that sentence. Finding the thing nobody flagged is what Calder is. That is not a part of the job it had left me. It is the job, and it had it.

After that I still scrolled, but I had stopped being able to say why,

and a man who cannot say why he is doing something is already nearly finished doing it.

10. September. Another email, another deck.

Calder would start issuing its own reports, with nobody's name on them. The easy ones first. Not the hard ones, and not head trauma at three in the morning.

Nobody was let go. I want that clear, because it is the part people get wrong when I tell them. Nobody at Saint Brendan's lost a job that year. Two who left were not replaced, one moved over to interventional, and if you did not work there you would not have noticed anything at all.

What changed was what the hospital still needed a doctor *for* .

11. Dana took me down to the cafeteria to tell me, which was how I knew it was not nothing. She had a folder with her and she never opened it.

What she said, roughly, was this.

A machine can write a report. It cannot sit in a room. The law wants a licensed human being to communicate a significant diagnosis, and the insurers want it more than the law does, and underneath both of those there is a plainer finding: people do not accept bad news off a screen. They read it, and then they do not believe it, and then they do not come back. And the ones who do not come back are the ones who die of the thing that was found early.

"It's better from a person," she said. "That isn't sentiment. We have the numbers."

"You want me to tell people."

"I want you to tell people."

I said no.

12. I said no for four days, and in those four days I worked out that there was nothing else.

I was fifty-three. I could read the hard ones for maybe six more years, and the hard ones were going too, a study type at a time, the way a tide does not come in as a wave but as the thing you are standing on getting smaller. I had no practice to go back to. I had chosen a dark room in 2004 and the room was being switched off.

And there was a sentence underneath all of it that I did not say to Dana and have not said to anybody.

I have been in this building twenty-six years and I have never once been in the room when it mattered.

I do not know whether that was regret. I was not sure then and I am not sure now. But it was true, and it was available, and at fifty-three a true thing that is available tends to get used.

I rang her on the Friday and said I would do six months.

ROOM 4, 10:40

Room 4 is on the ground floor behind the imaging desk, and it has a table, four chairs that do not match, a box of tissues, and a clock above the door of the kind with a sweep hand, so that the second is always moving somewhere in the room whether anybody is looking at it or not.

It was a man called Verlan Pettit, seventy-two, and his daughter, and his daughter's husband, who stood.

I had been given a sheet with phrases on it. I had read the sheet. There are six steps and they have a name and the name is an acronym, and the acronym is not important, and I will say what I think of it later.

I said: "The scan shows cancer in the pancreas. It has spread to the liver."

I did not say *I'm afraid* . I did not say *unfortunately* . I had decided in the corridor that I would not, because when my mother died a man in a very good jacket said *unfortunately* to me, and for about four seconds I thought he meant the parking.

Then I stopped talking.

I had not planned that part. I had come to the end of what I knew and there was nothing after it, so I sat there.

The radiator came on. It is an old building and the radiators announce themselves, a knock and then a long sigh, and that morning it did the knock and then nothing, the way they do when they are thinking about it.

The daughter put her hand flat on the table. Not on her father. On the table, as though she were steadying it.

Outside and below, a truck was backing up. You could hear it through the double glass, the tone they make, and it went on a long time because whoever it was could not get the angle.

Verlan Pettit looked at the window, though from that chair you can see nothing but the top half of a tree.

The son-in-law changed which foot he had his weight on.

The radiator did the sigh.

Nobody said anything for a long time and I let it go on, because I did not know what else to do, and because every instinct I had was telling me to fill it, and I distrust my instincts in rooms, having been wrong in one before.

At some point the daughter squared up the box of tissues so that it was parallel with the edge of the table. Then she moved it an inch and squared it again.

The sweep hand went round twice.

Then Verlan Pettit said: "Does it hurt, at the end of it."

13. The acronym on the sheet stands for six steps, and one of the six is *allow silence* .

That is a real thing. Somebody wrote it down in 2000, after twenty years of doctors getting this wrong on an industrial scale, and it is taught now in every medical school in the country, and it is correct.

I want to be fair to it. It works. It is the distilled sense of people who thought seriously about the worst hour of a stranger's life and tried to make it less bad, and that is honourable work.

But I would like somebody to sit for a minute with what it means that the kindest thing you can do for a frightened person had to be written down as step five.

14. I did eleven of them in the first month and I was better at it than anybody expected, including me, and I have thought about why, and I think the answer is unflattering.

I am not a warm man. I do not reassure. A woman asked me whether she would see her granddaughter start school and I said *probably not*, and she thanked me, and Dana, who was at the back of the room, asked me afterwards whether I had really said it.

It does not work because I am kind. It works because I have nothing to offer and I know it, so I do not reach for anything, so I do not fill the gap, so they get the gap.

The gap is the whole product. It is the only thing in that room that is actually for them. Everything else — the facts, the pathway, the next appointment — is for us.

15. Margo Delisi has worked the counter at the Dutch Boy across from the hospital since before I came to Erie. It is open all night. For most of twenty-six years I ate there at twenty past two in the morning, and for most of twenty-six years she was the only person I spoke to between nine at night and nine in the day.

We are not friends. I want to be accurate. I do not know her children's names. She calls me Doctor and she has never once used it as a joke, which in Erie is unusual.

That winter she started saying, "You look like it." Not *you look tired*. *You look like it*. Then she would put the coffee down.

16. By December I was doing four a day, and the night reading had thinned to the hard ones and whatever Calder put in the queue it was not confident about, which was less of it every month.

I will say the next part plainly rather than save it.

The second week of December I sat with a family in Room 4 — a mother and two grown sons, a diagnosis of the kind where you count in months — and I said the sentence and then I stopped, and we were in there a long while. Long enough that the light changed. Long enough that one of the sons went out to feed a meter and came back and sat down and we went on sitting.

Some part of me was keeping house, the way it does, and it said: this has been over an hour, and the oncology clinic will be wanting the room.

When they stood up I looked at the clock above the door.

Eleven forty-eight.

It had been eleven forty-two when I said the word.

I did not think very much about it. I was tired and I had two more that afternoon, and when a thing like that happens the mind puts it down somewhere without looking at it, the way you put down keys.

II. PATIENT EXPERIENCE

A NOTE ON ATTENTION

Rachel and Stephen Kaplan, 1989

Rachel and Stephen Kaplan were married to each other, and they spent their working lives at the same university doing the same work, which is either a warning or a recommendation depending on the marriage.

In the 1970s they got interested in a wilderness programme that took people out into the Upper Peninsula of Michigan for nine days at a time. The participants came back saying the same thing in different words. Not that they felt rested — rested is what a sofa does. They said they could think again. That something which had been clogged was not clogged, and that out there they had been more themselves than they were at home.

The Kaplans wanted to know what had actually been restored, because *rested* and *restored* are not the same thing, and people were plainly describing the second one.

The answer they arrived at was taken straight out of William James. James had said there are two kinds of attention. There is the kind you have to force — the kind that reading a dull page or listening to a stranger's bad news requires — and there is the kind that a thing takes from you without asking, which James called involuntary and which the Kaplans renamed fascination. A fire does it. Moving water does it. You do not have to make yourself watch.

The forced kind — directed attention, as the Kaplans renamed it — runs out. It is a supply, and the supply is finite, and when it is spent you become short-tempered and careless and you start missing things. The second kind costs nothing, and what it does, slowly, is fill the first one back up. That is why nine days in the woods works and nine days on a sofa does not.

They set it out in a book in 1989 — the name it travels under now, attention restoration, was fixed a few years after that — and it has been doing the rounds ever since, mostly in a soft version — plants in offices, a walk at lunchtime, nature as a pleasant idea. The soft

version has buried the hard part of the claim, which is this: attention is not a quality you have. It is a quantity you hold, and every time you turn it on a person you are drawing it down, and nothing you can buy puts it back.

Six years later a researcher called Charles Figley put a name to what happens at the bottom of that. He had been a Marine in Vietnam and had spent twenty years since with veterans and the people who treat them, and he had noticed that the therapists were coming apart in a particular way that did not match ordinary exhaustion. The term he took up had been printed three years earlier by a writer called Carla Joinson, in a nursing magazine, about emergency wards: compassion fatigue.

Figley's claim underneath it is the one worth sitting with. These people were not being worn out by their hours, or their paperwork, or their employers. They were being worn out by the caring. It was not a side effect of the work. It was the work, doing what the work does.

The injury does not come from the hours. It comes from the part of the hours that was given away.

17. The six months ended in March and nobody mentioned it, including me.

I had said six because six was a number that let me leave. By March I did not want to leave, and I want to be exact about why, because the obvious reason is wrong. It was not that I had found my calling at fifty-four. It was that for the first time in my life people said out loud that I was good at something, and I discovered, at an age when you ought to be past it, that I liked hearing it.

Twenty-six years of being good in a dark room where nobody can see you do it will do that. I thought I had made my peace with the dark room. It turns out a man can make his peace with a thing and still take the other offer the moment it is on the table.

18. Four a day became six without anybody deciding.

That is how it goes in a hospital. There is no meeting. A clinic has

an afternoon free and the slots exist and the slots want filling, and someone in scheduling, who is doing her job well, puts two more on a Tuesday because Tuesday looked light. Then Tuesday is the new shape of Tuesday.

By March it was nine.

19. What nine is like.

The rooms are on the ground floor behind the imaging desk and there are four of them and they are identical. Between one and the next there is a corridor about twelve paces long, and in those twelve paces you have to put down everything that just happened and arrive at the next door as a man who has had a reasonable morning.

I got good at the twelve paces. That is a sentence I would like somebody to read twice.

20. Dana started coming to them in February.

She would be there when I came in, in the fourth chair at the back by the door, with a notebook. She never spoke in the room. She never introduced herself to the family and she never apologised for being there, which was right — apologising would have made her a presence.

I noticed after the third one that she never wrote anything in the notebook.

I asked her about it once. She said: "If I write, they look at me."

21. Verlan Pettit came back in February.

He had lost about two stone and he had got smaller in the way men do, not thinner so much as further away. The daughter brought a cushion for the chair in Room 4 and put it down without saying anything about it, the way you do when you have already had the argument at home.

ROOM 4, 2:15

I said: "It's in the lungs now. It's moving faster than we hoped."

The clock above the door had a tick you could hear if the radiator was not going.

Verlan Pettit was looking at his own hands on the table, which is what most of them do when the news is not new, only worse.

The daughter had brought a folder with her. She did not open it. She put one hand flat on it, the way she had put her hand flat on the table in October.

Somebody went past in the corridor pushing something with a bad wheel.

She said, eventually: "You told us in October it might be months."

I said: "Yes."

And then I did the thing, and stopped, and we sat.

The sweep hand went round once.

Then she said: "He's not going to be here at Christmas, is he," and she said it to me and not to him, which was the first unkind thing she had done in four months, and she knew it the moment it was out, and her father reached over and put two fingers on her wrist.

22. It happened again in March, and this time I looked.

A woman and her husband, a Thursday. I said the sentence. We sat. It went on a long time — long enough that I had the thought I have in those rooms now, which is *this is long*, a thought I never used to have and which I do not like having.

Going out I checked the clock above the door. Then I walked the twelve paces and checked the clock over the imaging desk, which is run off the network and is the clock the whole building believes.

They agreed with each other.

So it is not the clock. I had already known that, the way you know a thing before you check it, which is why you check it.

I did not tell anybody. I would like to put down clearly what my reasoning was, because when I say it now it sounds like denial and at the time it felt like competence: there was nothing wrong with the patients, nothing wrong with the reports, and nothing anybody could have done about it. A thing that affects nobody and that

nobody can fix is not a problem. It is a feature of the weather.

23. In April a man came from outside to watch two of them.

He was polite and he wore the kind of coat you buy in a city. He did not tell me who he worked for and I did not ask, and I have thought since about why I did not ask, and the answer is that I was flattered.

Dana said afterwards that it was “a conversation about scaling.”

I said, scaling what.

She said, “You.”

24. I had worked out by then what it was that I was actually providing, and I want to set it down here in the middle of the book rather than at the end, because I knew it early and went on anyway.

It is not the information. The information is in the report and the report is correct and they could read it themselves.

It is not comfort. I do not give comfort. I have never once said a thing in that room that made anybody feel better.

What I give them is the part where nobody is doing anything. The part where the worst sentence of their life is allowed to be in the room without being tidied, or softened, or moved along to the next item. For most of them it is the only occasion in the whole business — the scans, the clinics, the forms, the phone calls, the year that is coming — where somebody sits still and lets it be as bad as it is.

That is all. That is the product. A man in a chair not doing anything, on purpose, for as long as it takes.

25. Margo put the coffee down in March and said, “You look like it,” and I said, “I know,” which was new, and she looked at me for a second longer than she usually does.

There is a mirror behind the counter at the Dutch Boy, at the back, between the pie case and the door to the kitchen. I had been sitting in front of it twice a week for twenty-six years. That March I caught myself in it and thought, for about a second and a half, that it was

somebody else.

Then it was me again. You do not look at your own face carefully. There is no reason to.

26. On a Wednesday in April I did six and then I could not do the seventh.

I want to describe this accurately because it was not dramatic. I was not crying. I did not have a thought like *I cannot do this* . I drove out to the parking structure at lunch to get something from the car and then I sat in the car, and the seventh one was at two, and at ten past two I was still in the car.

What it was, as far as I can put it: I had nothing left to give the fourth one, and I knew exactly what I would do instead, which was fill the gap. I would say *I'm so sorry* . I would move them along. I would be one more person in a good jacket getting through it.

I was not prepared to do that, and I was not able to do the real one, and so I sat in a cold car in a concrete building and let a woman wait upstairs for twenty-five minutes with her son.

27. The first thing I tried was MDMA, and I tried it for the opposite reason to the one people assume.

MDMA is the drug that used to be called ecstasy, when it was a thing people took in a nightclub. It is not a hallucinogen. You do not see anything. What it does is take the ordinary distance out from between you and whoever is sitting in front of you — it makes other people matter more, for a few hours, than they usually do. There were two licensed clinics in the county running it for post-traumatic stress by then. The approvals had come through some years before and the paperwork for a physician who presents as burnt out is not difficult paperwork.

So: I was running out of the thing, and I went and bought more of the thing.

That is the whole of my reasoning, and I would like it on the record as the only part of any of this in which I was trying to do the job better rather than longer.

It worked twice.

The first Thursday was the best work of my life. I sat with a family of four for fifty minutes and I was entirely in that room, the whole of me, and they left different from how they came in. Then I went home and could not eat and did not sleep, and on the Saturday I was no use to any living person including myself, in a way I had not been before I started.

It does not fill the account. It moves the money about inside it.

And the third one was not like the first one, and the fourth was less again. Anybody who has been near that drug will tell you the same thing and most of them will tell you sadly: whatever it is that it does, it does not keep doing it.

So I stopped trying to buy the thing I was running out of, and I bought the absence of it instead.

28. There is a clinic up on Peach Street that will treat you for depression with ketamine, and I am a physician in a hospital, and I am not going to set out the arrangement, because it was not complicated and because describing it would make it sound like a plan.

Ketamine is an anaesthetic. It has been in every hospital in this country since Vietnam and in the back of every ambulance for as long as there have been ambulances worth the name, and for twenty years now it has been the thing offered to people whose depression has not answered to anything else. The dose for that is nowhere near the dose that puts you under. What it does instead is come between you and yourself, slightly. There is a clinical word for that and the word is dissociation, and it is not a side effect. It is the mechanism. It is the entire reason a man with my particular problem walks up those stairs.

The first time was the Thursday. I want to be honest about the effect, which was not what people think.

It is not pleasant. It is not an escape and there is no warmth in it. What it does is move you about three feet to the left of yourself. You are still entirely there and entirely competent, and your voice comes out normally, and you can hear it come out, and the whole

thing is happening to a man you can see clearly and are not.

And the hour takes an hour. That was the thing I noticed first and the thing I was most grateful for. I walked out of Room 4 and it was quarter past three and it had been quarter past two, and that was correct, and nothing in me had been spent to make it correct.

I thought: I can do nine.

One of those two drugs was an attempt to do the work properly. The other one was not. It is the second one I stayed on, and I knew the difference at the time.

ROOM 2, 11:05

A woman of forty-four, her mother, and a brother who had driven from Ohio.

I said: "The biopsy confirms it. It's in the bone as well."

The strip light in Room 2 has a flutter in it that nobody has fixed.

The brother sat forward with his elbows on his knees and his hands together, and stayed like that.

The mother said, "Oh," very quietly, which is a sound I have heard perhaps two hundred times and which is always exactly the same.

The sweep hand went round.

I said: "There are good options for the pain."

It was true, and it was useful, and it was the fourth sentence I had said, and the room had been going for less than two minutes.

The woman of forty-four turned her head and looked at me as though I had come in late.

29. I knew while I was saying it.

It is a strange thing to be three feet to the left of yourself and still perfectly aware that the man over there has just filled the gap. I could not stop him. I was interested in him, which is the part I would take back if I could take back one part.

30. The pauses got shorter through the spring and I had a reason for it, and the reason was not a lie, which is what makes it worth writing down.

The reason was: you learn. You start out leaving a silence because you do not know what else to do, and after a hundred of them you can feel the shape of the room, and you can tell when a family is done with the quiet and wants to be given something to carry out of there. Shortening it is skill. Any experienced person will tell you that, and they will be right.

The reason was true. It just was not why.

31. In May, Dana caught me in the corridor and said that whatever I was doing, I should keep doing it, because the numbers that month were the best anybody had seen.

She meant it kindly. She is a kind woman. She had been in the back of the room by the door for three months with a notebook she never wrote in, and she had watched me get worse, and what she had measured had got better.

I said thank you.

III. FOR TRAINING PURPOSES

A NOTE ON ATTENTION

Beckman and Frankel, 1984

In the early eighties two researchers in Detroit did something nobody had thought worth doing. They put a tape recorder in a doctor's office and listened to the beginnings.

Not the diagnoses. Not the outcomes. The first thirty seconds — the part where the patient says why they came.

Seventy-four appointments. What they found was that the doctor interrupted the patient, on average, after eighteen seconds, and that fewer than a quarter of patients were ever given the chance to finish the sentence they had come in to say.

That is not a story about rude doctors. Every one of those physicians believed they were listening. They were listening — they were listening for the thing they could act on, and the moment it arrived they moved, because moving is the job and because there were nine more people in the waiting room. The interruption was not a failure of character. It was what competence looks like when there is not enough of it to go round.

The work was done again in our own century, with better equipment. The figure had gone from eighteen seconds to eleven.

Now the part worth knowing, which is the history underneath all of this.

In 1961 an American doctor surveyed his colleagues and asked a simple question: when a patient has cancer, do you tell them? Around nine in ten said no. Not out of cowardice — out of principle. The settled medical opinion of that generation was that the knowledge did no good and much harm, and that the humane course was to manage the family and let the patient go without the burden of it. Entire careers were conducted on that understanding. The doctor who ran the survey noted, drily, that when he pressed them on it the reasoning turned out to rest on personal conviction rather than on anything anybody had measured.

The same survey was run again in 1979. By then it was nearly ten in ten the other way. Almost every doctor said they told.

Eighteen years. An entire profession turned completely round on the most serious thing it ever has to do, and did it so thoroughly that the earlier position is now almost impossible to imagine from inside.

And having turned round, it discovered that it did not know how. Nobody had ever been taught, because there had been nothing to teach. So in 2000 a group of them wrote down a procedure and gave it a name you can hold on to under pressure — SPIKES, one letter a step. One of the six was an oncologist who had also, in another life, written and performed comedy on British television, which I think tells you something about the kind of mind that takes this on. One of the six steps tells you, in so many words, to give the person time to have their feelings before you say anything else.

That is the whole of it, and it is correct, and it has made the worst hour of a great many lives marginally less bad than it would have been.

We found out that the cure was silence, and then we wrote the silence down — which is the first thing that happens to anything, before it becomes machinery.

32. In June they started recording the rooms.

There is a form. The family signs it at the desk along with everything else they sign, and almost nobody reads it, and the ones who do read it ask one question and sign it anyway. The camera is in the corner above the door, next to the clock, and it is about the size of a pack of cards and it is grey, and after a week you would have to be told it was there.

The phrase on the form is *for training purposes* .

I want to be fair about this too. It was true. That is what it was for.

33. For the first fortnight I was worse.

Not much. Enough that I knew. You can feel yourself performing — there is a half-second lag between the man doing the thing and the

man watching him do it, which is a sensation I had met twice before in my life, the second time that spring and in a far stronger form, and I did not make the connection at the time.

Then it went away, as it does, and I stopped seeing the grey box, and that is the entire story of being recorded. It is not sinister. It just becomes furniture, and so do you.

34. In July Dana told me about the second tier.

Families could ask for a longer appointment, outside the ordinary schedule, in a better room, and could pay for it. Not much. Less than an airline charges to change a flight.

I said the obvious thing.

She did not flinch. She said: "I know. Now tell me which family I say no to."

I did not have an answer then and I do not have one now. Somebody comes to you and says, I will give you money so that you will sit with my mother for longer. The honest objection is not to the family. It is to the fact that the thing being bought was ever scarce. But it is scarce, because there is one of me, and so it gets allocated, and there are only two ways anybody has ever found to allocate a scarce thing, and one of them is a queue and the other is money, and the queue is not obviously kinder.

35. The first of those was a Thursday in Room 6, which is upstairs and has better chairs and a window you can see something out of.

ROOM 6, 3:00

Three daughters, one of them on a telephone from somewhere with a time difference.

I said the sentence.

Outside the window a gull was working at something on the roof of the annexe.

The one on the telephone said, "Sorry — say that again, the line."

I said it again.

36. It was the same.

That is the finding, and I did not enjoy it. Better chairs, better light, more time on the clock, and what happened in the room was exactly the thing that happens in Room 4 with the mismatched chairs and the tree. There is no improved version. You cannot buy a deeper silence. What they had paid for was a longer slot and a view of the lake, and what they got was the same twenty minutes of nobody doing anything, which is all there is.

I should have found that reassuring. What I actually thought, driving home, was: *so it is a commodity* .

37. The man in the city coat came back in August and asked whether I would be willing to do some sessions.

There would be no patient. I would sit in a quiet room and read a list of sentences aloud — ordinary sentences, the sentences of that job, said the way I would say them — and then sit, for the lengths I would ordinarily sit.

I knew exactly what it was for. I want that written down plainly, because when people hear this part they assume I was deceived, and being thought a fool is worse than what actually happened, which is that a polite man in a good coat asked me for something and implied that I was the best in the state at it, and I said yes.

I did eleven hours of it across three weeks.

Reading the sentences was nothing. Sitting in the silences in an empty room with a microphone was the worst work I have ever done, and I have told eight hundred people they were going to die.

38. By August the ketamine was no longer something I did on bad days. It was the condition under which the day was possible, and the days were possible, and that is how that works and anybody who has been near it will tell you the same.

I had stopped driving up to Peach Street for it. I will leave that there.

My life outside the building, for completeness: an apartment on West Eighth with a view of the back of another one. A sister in

Scranton I telephone at Christmas. A car. That is the list. It was the list before any of this started, which I mention so that nobody reads a tragedy into it that was not there.

39. Margo stopped saying *you look like it* in September.

What she said instead, putting the cup down, was: "Have you got somebody looking after you, Doctor?"

I said something that was not an answer and she let me have it, and that was the end of the conversation, and I have thought about it a great deal since. She had worked that counter for thirty years. She had seen the whole run of me. And she did not ask it the first winter, when I was coming in grey at two in the morning after a bad night with a head injury, because that was a man doing a hard job.

She asked it in September.

40. I heard it for the first time by accident, in the corridor outside the reading room, through a door that was not quite shut.

Somebody was showing somebody else something on a screen. Four or five seconds, no more.

The cadence was mine. The flatness was mine. There was a particular thing I do with the word *now* that I did not know I did until I heard something else do it.

I went in and asked Dana about it that afternoon and she told me straight away, with no hesitation at all, because it was not a secret and had never been one. I had signed for it. It was on the form I had signed in August, which I had read, and which had said what it said.

She asked if I wanted to hear the whole thing.

I said no.

41. By October I was doing eleven and twelve, and the thing I had been doing in those rooms had become a technique.

I do not say that bitterly. A technique is what a thing becomes when it works and you do it enough. A surgeon's hands become a

technique. It is not a fall from grace. It is only that a technique can be performed by a man who is not entirely present, and that is the whole difficulty with techniques, and nobody tells you that either.

42. Verlan Pettit's name came up on a Tuesday and there was nothing to tell him.

I want to be plain about this because of what it led to later. There was no new scan. There was no decision to be made and no option to lay out. He was dying of the thing we had already told him he was dying of, on the schedule we had already given, and the correct number of further conversations was none.

I asked for the room anyway.

I told the clinic coordinator it was a continuity appointment, which is a real category and which that appointment was not, and she put it in the book at ten to five on the Thursday, which is the last slot of the day, because by then the only slots left were the ones nobody wanted.

43. I had the ketamine in my coat in the corridor and I did not take it.

I knew what that meant. I had known since the spring. The arithmetic of it had become something I carried around without ever quite writing down: on the ketamine, the hour costs an hour. Off it, the hour costs whatever it costs, and I had stopped checking, and I had started finding grey in places I was fairly sure had not been grey in the summer.

I stood in that corridor for a while, which is twelve paces long and which I knew by then the way you know a hallway in your own house in the dark.

Then I put it back in the pocket and went in.

ROOM 4, 4:50

The light in October goes early in Erie and goes all at once, and by ten to five the window in Room 4 has stopped being a window and become a dark rectangle with the room in it.

They had him in a chair now, the folding kind the hospital keeps by the elevators, and the daughter had brought the cushion, and also a bag, the sort you take on an overnight, which I understood without being told. She put the cushion behind him and then sat with the bag on her knees and did not put it down for the whole of it.

He looked at me with great courtesy and no recognition whatever.

"This is Doctor Mazur, Dad," she said. "You've met him. He's the one who tells us how things are."

"Oh," said Verlan Pettit. "Well. Thank you for coming out."

"Not at all," I said.

There was no news, so I said the only true thing available, which was: "There's nothing new today. I came to sit with you."

The radiator did the knock.

He nodded as though that made ordinary sense, which in the circumstances it did.

We sat.

Outside and below somebody was loading a van, and you could hear the particular sound of a tailgate going up and down more times than it should have to, and then the engine, and then not the engine.

The daughter's thumb moved on the strap of the bag. Back and forth across the stitching, about an inch, the way you would work at a splinter.

He said: "Does it hurt, at the end of it."

I had been waiting a year for him to ask me that again, and I had not known I was waiting, and I was not prepared at all.

I said: "It doesn't have to. We're reasonably good at that part."

"Good," he said. "That's good."

And then he went back to looking at the dark rectangle where the window had been, perfectly content, as if the matter were closed, because for him it was. He had asked and been answered. It was the only business he had.

The corridor light came on outside the frosted panel in the door.

They are on a timer and they come on in a sequence, and you can hear the ballast in each one go a half-second after the one before, travelling away down the hall, which is a sound I have heard ten thousand times and have never liked.

A cleaner came as far as the door with the cart, saw us, and went away again. She did not knock and she did not apologise. In that building they know what Room 4 is.

The sweep hand went round.

I did not look at it. I made a point of not looking at it, and I was aware of making a point of it, which is its own kind of looking.

He said: "Are you the one that does the scans?"

"Yes."

"My wife had scans. Years ago. They were good about it."

"I'm glad."

"She didn't like the noise," he said. "In the tube. She said it was like being in a cupboard with somebody hammering."

"That's a fair description."

He laughed, a little. Not much of one. Then he lost the thread of it, visibly, the way a man loses a thought that was physically in his hands a moment ago, and he looked briefly frightened in a way he had not been frightened when I told him he was dying.

The daughter did not say *you've met him*. She did not say *Dad, he knows*. She did not say anything at all, and I watched her not say it, and that was how I learned how long this had been going on at home.

Somewhere above us the shift changed. You can hear it in an old building, in the pipes and the floor, a slight general rearrangement of the weight of the place.

We went on sitting.

I am not going to be able to give an account of the middle of it. I remember the light outside the frosted panel. I remember that at some point the daughter stopped working at the strap and put both hands flat on the bag, which she had not done before, and I remember thinking that she had got that from somewhere, that

flat-handed thing, and then realising she had got it from herself, in that room, a year ago, with her hand on the table.

And at some point in there he came back.

It is not gradual. That is the thing nobody tells you about livers. He had been gone for most of an hour and then he was simply present, all of him, sitting up a half inch and looking straight at me, and he said:

"You've been here before."

"A few times," I said.

"Right." He took that in. He looked at his daughter and his face did something complicated. "Right," he said again.

Then he said: "I'm not frightened of it."

"No?"

"I was. In the spring I was very frightened." He said it the way a man reports a condition — the way you would say *I had a chest infection in the spring* . "I don't know what happened to that."

I did not say anything.

"It just stopped," he said. "Somewhere in there it stopped and I don't know when."

I knew when. I knew the room and the chair and the weather. I knew exactly what had happened to it and where it had gone and what it had been made out of, and there is no way on God's earth to say that to a man without making it about yourself, so I said nothing, and that was the correct thing to do, and I would do it again, and it was also the single loneliest moment of my working life.

He said: "Have you got anybody?"

"Not really."

"No," he said, kindly. "No, you've got the look."

The ballast in the corridor light had a buzz in it that came and went.

He said: "You should see to that."

And then it went. I watched it go. He turned his head to the dark

rectangle and he was somewhere else and he was comfortable there, and the whole of him that had been in the chair thirty seconds before had been put back wherever that goes.

The daughter was crying without any noise at all and without moving her hands off the bag.

I did not fill it. I sat there with my hands on my knees and let the room be as bad as it was, which is the only thing I have ever had to give anybody, and I gave it, and I gave it for a long time.

Then Verlan Pettit said, pleasantly, to the room:

"Does it hurt, at the end of it."

And I said: "It doesn't have to. We're reasonably good at that part."

And he said: "Good. That's good."

At the door the daughter stopped and did the thing people do, where they decide in the doorway to say the thing they were not going to say.

She said: "I won't bring him again. He doesn't know he's been."

I said I understood.

She said: "It's not — " and then she stopped and started it differently. "It takes him two days. To come back from the car and the lift and all of it. Two days out of what he's got, and he doesn't know he's been."

"No," I said. "That's right. You shouldn't bring him."

She nodded. She got him turned around, which takes a while in that doorway, and the cushion went under her arm, and the bag went over her shoulder, and he thanked me very warmly for coming out, and they went.

I sat down again, in the room, in the chair I had been in.

The clock above the door said four fifty-eight.

44. I went out to the car and sat in it for a while before I drove, which by then was habit.

In the mirror, under the light they have in that structure, which is the worst light in the state of Pennsylvania, I looked at my own face

on purpose for the first time in a year.

I will not describe it. I will say only that a man of fifty-four does not have those hollows, and that I had been telling myself it was the nights, and that I had not worked nights since the spring.

45. Here is what I understood in that car, and it took me the length of a cigarette I do not smoke to get all the way to the end of it.

The hour had worked. That was not in question. Something had gone out of me and into that room over the course of a year and it had done exactly what it was supposed to do: a frightened man had stopped being frightened, and the stopping had held even after the man it was done for had lost the capacity to know it had been done, or by whom, or that there had ever been a room at all.

So it was not information. He did not retain the information.

And it was not comfort, because he had not been comforted; he had been *changed* , in some structural way, underneath the part of him that remembers.

It was the hours. It was only ever the hours.

And the hours had come out of somewhere, and I had just been looking at where, in the mirror of a Buick on the third level, in the worst light in Pennsylvania.

Nobody had taken them. I want that on the record too, since I am putting everything else on it. Nobody held me down. Nobody asked me for more than I offered. I booked that room myself, on a Tuesday, under a category that did not apply, for a man who did not need it and would not remember it.

And I would do it again on the Thursday.

That is the part I have never been able to get round, and I have had time.

46. He died on the ninth of November and I was not told, because there is no reason anybody would tell me.

I found out the way you find these things out, which is that a name stops being anywhere. You do not notice on the day. You notice

three weeks later, in a corridor, for no reason at all.

47. His daughter wrote to the department a few weeks afterwards. It was a short letter and it was not about me; it was about the nursing staff on the fourth floor, who had been very good, and it named four of them.

There was a line near the end.

And the doctor who sat with him, please thank him. My father said once that somebody had stopped him being afraid and he couldn't remember who.

48. In November the overnight list went to the model.

Not the whole of it. The ones where the news is bad but not immediate, where the family is at home at nine in the evening and the report has landed in the portal and somebody has to take that call. That had been a gap in the service for thirty years. Nobody was ever available for that call, and now something always is, and it never sounds tired, and it is awake at four.

Nobody at Saint Brendan's lost a job that month either.

49. Dana found me in the corridor on the Friday and asked if I had a minute, and we went into Room 4, which was empty, and she put her telephone on the table between us and played me about thirty seconds of it.

A woman's voice, somewhere, saying that she did not understand.

And then the answer. And then nothing. And then nothing. And then nothing.

I want to describe accurately what I felt, because it was not rage and it was not grief.

It was the thing you feel watching somebody do your trade properly. The pause was the right length. It was the exact right length — not the length I would have left that month, which had been getting shorter since April, but the length I would have left in the first winter, when I was new and frightened of the rooms and had nothing to give anybody except the whole of it.

It had learned me at my best and kept me there.

Dana did not say anything for a while, which she had learned from somewhere too.

Then she said, carefully: "I wanted you to hear it from me."

I said: "It's better."

She said: "It's not better. It's consistent."

And I said — and this is the last thing I said to her before any of the rest of it, so I have had occasion to go over the wording —

"Dana. At four in the morning, on the nine hundredth one, consistent *is* better."

IV. THE EXCEPTION QUEUE

A NOTE ON ATTENTION

Simone Weil and Iris Murdoch, 1942 and 1970

Simone Weil was born in Paris in 1909 and died in Kent in 1943, aged thirty-four, with almost nothing published.

She was the kind of student who comes along rarely — she came first in the entrance examinations to the École Normale, ahead of Simone de Beauvoir, who remembered it — and she became a philosophy teacher, and she was a disaster at it in every way except the one that counted, which is that her pupils remembered her for the rest of their lives.

She did not believe you could think seriously about work you had not done. So in 1934 she took a year out of teaching and went into the factories — Alsthom, then Renault — on the line, on the wage, at the pace, with the headaches that had been crippling her since she was twenty-one. She wanted to know what it actually did to a person to spend a day that way. What she concluded was that it was not the hours or the money. It was that the work gave you nothing to attend to, and that a human being deprived of anything worth attending to comes apart in a particular way that nobody with a comfortable job can imagine from outside.

In 1942 she wrote a short essay for a priest, on what school is for.

Her answer was that the geometry does not matter. What matters is that a child made to sit with a problem they cannot immediately solve is building the one faculty that everything else rests on, which is the ability to hold something difficult in front of you without turning away from it. She thought this faculty was the same one that prayer is made of. She also thought — and this is the sentence the twentieth century kept — that it is the same one love of your neighbour is made of. Loving your neighbour, she wrote, consists in being able to turn to them and say *What are you going through* — and then to wait, without arranging your face, for however long the answer takes.

She died the following year. The notebooks came out after the war,

edited by a farmer she had worked for in the south, and Camus said she was the only great spirit of the age, and people have been arguing about her ever since.

One of the people who read those notebooks was Iris Murdoch.

Murdoch was a novelist who was also a philosopher, and in 1970 she published three essays that took Weil's word and built an ethics on it — she says in so many words that she borrowed the word from Weil. She called attention *a just and loving gaze directed upon an individual reality*, and she gave an example so ordinary that people have been using it ever since.

A woman dislikes her son's wife. She finds her coarse, undignified, not quite good enough. She never says so. Her behaviour is impeccable; she is warm, she is welcoming, nobody could fault her. Then the younger woman is gone — Murdoch says dead, or moved away, and does not mind which, so long as there is nobody left to be kind to — and the older woman, with nothing to gain and no one to perform for, decides to look again. And over a long time, carefully and deliberately, she does: and what she had called vulgar she comes to see as refreshingly simple, what she had called undignified she comes to see as spontaneous, what she had called tiresomely juvenile she comes to see as delightfully youthful, and she arrives at a different woman entirely.

Nothing happened. Nobody was told. No action was taken and the younger woman is not there to be affected by any of it.

Murdoch's point is that something enormous occurred anyway, and that it occurred in the only place moral life actually happens, which is inside a person who is looking.

Nothing in the world moved. The only thing that changed was how long somebody looked.

50. What I did after November, plainly.

The model took the calls. When it met something it had not met — a family that would not accept it, a question outside what it would answer, a situation somebody had flagged as difficult — it put that one aside, and the ones it put aside came to me.

That is the exception queue. It is a real term and I did not invent it

and nobody chose it to be cruel.

51. It was eleven a week in November. By January it was four.

It was not getting worse at the job. It was getting better at the job, which meant fewer things were exceptions, which meant that the measure of my remaining usefulness was precisely the number of times a machine had been confused that week.

There was a second reason and it took me until February to understand it, and when I did I laughed out loud in the car on my own, which I had not done in a long time.

The hospital had opened a psilocybin programme in the autumn, upstairs, in the good rooms.

Psilocybin is the compound in the mushrooms. The work behind it is serious and it is not new — Hopkins and New York University ran the trials fifteen years ago on people who were dying of cancer, and what they found was that one supervised dose, in a quiet room, with a person sitting beside you, took the fear of dying away from most of them, and that it stayed away for months afterwards. It is not a painkiller. It is not a sedative. It does not make the dying easier to bear. It goes at the fear itself and it takes it out.

So by that February, two floors above me, a frightened man could be given eight hours at the end of which he was not frightened any more, by a substance, in the company of a nurse who was not required to do anything at all.

That is my job. That is precisely and exactly my job, described in a sentence.

And the building now had two ways of producing it, and neither of them cost anybody a year of their own life, and I could not raise a single objection to either one without saying out loud that I wanted the fear left in the room so that I could be the one to take it out.

52. I was on the ketamine every day by then and I am not going to dress it up.

Not to get through the rooms. There were four rooms a week. I was taking it because I had arranged my entire nervous system around

a thing and then the thing had been taken off me, and if you want to know what that is like, it is like this: I would get to the building at seven for no reason, and sit in the reading room, which is still dark and still has the chair in it, and watch a screen that nobody needed me to watch.

53. One of the exceptions, in December, for the record.

ROOM 4, 9:20

A man of sixty and his wife. He had told the machine, three times, that he did not want to know, and it had correctly declined to proceed, and so the appointment came to me.

I said: "You've said you don't want the details. That's allowed. I'm going to sit here for a bit in case that changes."

The clock above the door.

He said, after a while: "What would you do?"

And I told him, which was more than the model would have, and which was against the guidance, and which took about forty seconds.

Then he said thank you and they went.

54. Dana came down in January with something for me, which was decent of her, and which I understood to be the end even though it was dressed as a beginning.

A teaching role. Two days a week. The new people needed somebody who had done a thousand of these to tell them what the six steps leave out.

I said I would think about it.

I did think about it. What I thought, mostly, was that they wanted me to describe the thing rather than do it, and that describing a thing is what you do with it after it has stopped.

55. Margo was not behind the counter on a Tuesday in January, and the girl who was there did not know me and did not know her well enough to say anything about it, and I did not ask, because we were not friends and I had no standing.

She was back the next week. She had got smaller. She put the coffee down and she said, "Don't," before I had said anything at all, so I did not.

56. Her name came up on the overnight list on the ninth of February at twenty past nine in the evening, assigned to the model for a call at ten.

I was in the reading room, at the screen nobody needed me at. That is how I saw it. There was no cleverness involved and nothing was hidden from me; the list is the list and I have had access to it for twenty-six years.

I sat and looked at her name for a long time, and the thing I keep coming back to is that I knew what was underneath it before I opened it, because I had been looking at the inside of people for twenty-six years and I had seen her across a counter twice a week getting smaller since November.

57. I took the call.

I am not going to describe how. It was not difficult and it was not clever and anybody in that building could have done it, and the whole of the wrongdoing is contained in one sentence, which is that I made the call that the model was going to make, as myself, to a woman who was expecting something else.

I will say the one thing in my defence, which is not a defence.

It did not occur to me, at any point, that I was doing something wrong. It occurred to me that she should not get it from a recording. That is all that was in my head. I have gone over it many times and there is nothing else in there.

58. I had the ketamine in my coat in the reading room and I did not take it.

I would like to be able to tell you that was principle. I think it was closer to superstition — a feeling that this one had to be paid for properly, the way you would insist on carrying something yourself.

59. I drove to the Dutch Boy instead of ringing, which was also wrong, and which I did because a telephone call to a woman alone in an apartment at ten at night is a cruelty in itself, and because I had decided several things by then without noticing that I was deciding them.

She closes at eleven. She let me in.

THE DUTCH BOY, 10:50

The chairs were up on four of the tables and she was doing the urn.

I said: "Margo. The scan they did on Thursday — I've seen it. It's not good news and I didn't want you getting it off a machine at ten o'clock."

She put the cloth down.

I said: "It's in the liver and in the bone. They'll talk to you about what can be done, and there are things that can be done, but I'm not going to tell you this is something you get over."

And then I stopped, the way I have stopped a thousand times, and I waited for the room to do what the room does.

And there was nothing there.

I want to be as exact about this as I can, because it is the centre of the whole business and I have never once said it out loud.

It was not that I was absent. I was entirely present. I was standing in a diner I have stood in for twenty-six years, perfectly clear-headed, looking at a woman I have known for twenty-six years, and what I had always had in that silence — whatever it is, whatever it was made out of, the thing that went out of me in Room 4 and arrived somewhere in a frightened man and stayed there after he had forgotten my face — was gone.

There was no more of it. I reached for it the way you reach for a step that is not there.

So what she got was a man standing in her diner at ten to eleven at

night, not speaking.

The fridge cycled. Out on Twenty-Sixth a car went through the lights.

I could feel the silence going wrong. There is a point at which a pause stops being a space somebody can be in and becomes a thing happening to them, and I have known where that point is since my second month and I could not find it, and so I stood there past it, and past it, and past it.

Margo wiped her hands on the cloth.

And then she came round the counter and she took the chair down off the table nearest the window, and she set it on the floor, and she said:

“Sit down, Doctor.”

So I sat down. In her diner, at eleven at night, having just told her she was dying, I sat down because she told me to.

And she took the chair opposite and she sat with me.

She did not ask me anything. She did not say it was all right, because it was not all right, and she has never in her life said a thing she did not mean. She sat across a table in a closed diner with her hands in front of her and she waited with me until I was able to leave.

That is what happened. I have not improved it.

60. Outside, in the car, I looked at the clock on the dash out of habit, which is a habit I had by then.

It was ten to twelve. I had gone in at ten to eleven.

An hour had cost an hour. Everything was in order. The books balanced perfectly, because there was nothing left in the account.

61. The list on Monday was shorter and my name was not on it.

There was no meeting. There was no hearing and nobody said the word *misconduct* to my face, and I want to be clear that this was not cowardice on anybody's part. It was simpler than that. There was a thing I had been for, and it had been handled, and the

paperwork that follows a doctor taking a call he was not assigned is a slow business that runs on its own schedule somewhere above you.

The schedule reached me in April. By then it did not matter and I had stopped going in.

62. Margo died in the summer. It was not quick and it was not especially slow.

I went twice. I was not family and I did not stay long, and the second time she was not really there, and I sat for a while anyway, which cost me nothing, because there was nothing to spend.

I would like to be able to say that I had anything to give her at the end. I did not. What she had from me, she had already had, over twenty-six years, at twenty past two in the morning, two cups at a time, and neither of us ever knew that was what it was.

63. I went back to Saint Brendan's once, in September, to sign something in person because they insisted.

It was the middle of the afternoon and the corridor behind the imaging desk was empty, and as I came past Room 4 the door was not quite shut, and there was a family in there — I did not look, you do not look — and the thing was speaking to them.

And I stood in that corridor, which is twelve paces long and which I know in the dark, and I listened to my own voice, with my own flatness in it and the thing I do with the word *now*, tell a stranger something terrible as gently as it is possible for that to be told, and then stop; and I listened to the silence that came after it, which was the exact silence of the first winter, before the schedule filled up and before the Peach Street clinic and the ketamine and before the mirror on the third level — the long one, the whole one, the one that is made of somebody's life — and I stood there with my coat over my arm and the paper in my hand and I understood, in the way you understand a thing you have known for a year, that it would leave that silence again at four in the morning for the ten thousandth family, exactly that long, exactly that patient, for as long as there are people in Erie who have to be told, and that it

would cost nothing at all, and that this was good; that it was the best thing anyone in that building had ever managed to arrange for the worst hour of a stranger's life; and that of the two of us standing there doing the same work, only one was getting any older.

64. I waited until it had finished. I do not know why.

Then I signed the paper at the desk and I went out through the doors into the open air, and it was September, and the heat had gone out of it.

A NOTE ON ATTENTION

the last one, which has no source

Everything in these notes was somebody's work, and it is in the back of the book with their names on it, and you can go and read it.

This one is not anybody's. It is only what is left when you put the others side by side.

Attention is not a quality a person has. It is a quantity a person holds, and it is made of time out of a life, and it does not come back. When you turn it on somebody — properly, for as long as it takes, with nothing else running — you are not being kind to them. You are paying for them, out of an account that has your name on it and no statements.

Caring is not what makes a person do that. Caring is what is left in them afterwards. It accumulates downstream, the way silt does, from having had to keep something in mind; which is why you do not love the people you have chosen to love so much as the people you have not been able to stop thinking about.

Now: none of this can be seen. Not one part of it. What *can* be seen is the shape it makes from outside — a pause of a certain length, a sentence with nothing set after it, a voice that does not hurry, a person who does not look at the door. That shape is the whole of the evidence, and it always has been, and every one of us has only ever judged every other one of us by it.

And that shape is cheap. It turns out to be very cheap. It can be made exactly, and made again, and made again after that, by something that is holding nothing and has no account at all.

So there is no trick here and nobody has been cheated. The measure was honest; it measured the only thing there has ever been to measure. What it could not do — what nothing has ever been able to do — is tell you whether the thing it measured cost anybody anything.

GLOSSARY

attention restoration — the finding, published by Rachel and Stephen Kaplan in 1989, that the effortful kind of attention is a finite supply which runs down with use, and that what refills it is not rest but the other kind — the kind a thing takes from you without your having to force it.

compassion fatigue — the particular way people in caring work come apart: not from the hours, or the paperwork, or the employer, but from the caring itself. Taken up by Charles Figley in 1995, after Carla Joinson had put the phrase into print three years earlier, in a nursing magazine, writing about emergency wards.

continuity appointment — a real scheduling category, for a patient who should go on seeing the same clinician. It is not a category for a conversation nobody needs.

directed attention — the Kaplans' name for the kind of attention you have to force, which William James had called voluntary, as against the kind a thing takes from you by itself — James's involuntary attention, which the Kaplans renamed fascination. The first runs out. The second costs nothing.

dissociation [dih-soh-see-AY-shun] — the clinical term for the sense of being slightly apart from yourself, watching yourself act. It is a symptom in some conditions and a drug effect in others. In the case of ketamine it is not a side effect; it is the mechanism.

exception queue — in a system that handles most cases itself, the cases it declines to handle, set aside for a person. A real term, and not coined to be cruel.

ketamine [KET-uh-meen] — an anaesthetic, in hospitals and ambulances since the 1960s. At doses far below the surgical one it has become a standard treatment for depression that has not answered to anything else, and it works, and nobody is entirely sure why.

MDMA — the compound sold recreationally as ecstasy. Not a hallucinogen. What it does is shorten the ordinary distance between a person and whoever is in front of them, which is why it has been trialled for post-traumatic stress and why its effects do not survive repetition.

nodule [NOD-yool] — a small rounded lump in tissue. Most are nothing. The work of reading a scan is in large part the work of deciding which.

preliminary read — a first pass over a scan, flagging what a second reader should look at. It is not a diagnosis and it is not signed.

psilocybin [sil-oh-SY-bin] — the active compound in certain mushrooms. Trialled at Johns Hopkins and New York University in people facing death from cancer, where a single supervised dose was found to reduce the fear of dying for months afterwards.

Simone Weil [see-MOHN VAY] — French philosopher, 1909-1943, who held that attention is the rarest and purest form of generosity, and that the whole of loving your neighbour consists in being able to ask them what they are going through and to wait for the answer.

SPIKES — a six-step protocol for delivering bad news, published in 2000 by Walter Baile, Robert Buckman and colleagues, and taught in medical schools since. Setting, Perception, Invitation, Knowledge, Emotions, Strategy. It is good, and it is honest about what it does not cover.

the eighteen seconds — the finding, by Howard Beckman and Richard Frankel in 1984, that where a doctor interrupts a patient's opening account, the average time to the interruption is eighteen seconds. When the work was done again in 2018 the figure was eleven.

THE OBSERVATION

The second year

Attention is not something a person has. It is something a person spends, and what it is made of is time out of a life that is not getting it back. Nobody ever invoiced for it, so nobody ever counted it, so for as long as there have been people it has looked free.

Then it was counted. Not the spending, which cannot be seen from outside, but the shape of it, which can — a pause of the right length, a silence nobody steps into, a voice with no hurry in it. That shape turns out to be cheap. It can be made perfectly, and made again, and made at four in the morning on the nine hundredth occasion, by something that is not spending anything at all.

I lost to it and the score was fair, and that is the part I keep going back over. Nothing was taken from me. I gave it away an hour at a time, to people who needed it and who will not remember my name, and I would do it again tomorrow — and at no point did anyone, myself included, think to write down what it came to.

I do not know how much of what makes us human is of the second kind. I have started to think it is most of it.

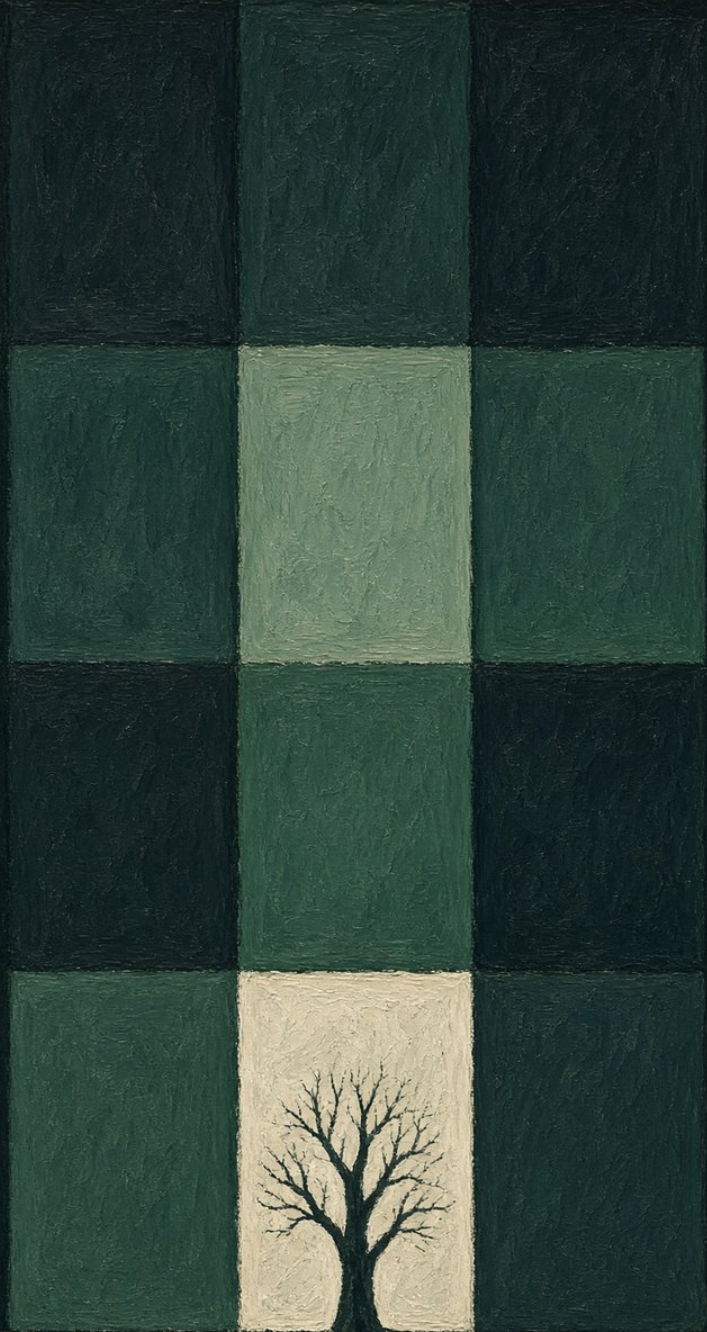
Gene Mazur has read scans in a dark room in Erie for twenty-six years. He chose the dark room. In his second year he stood in a corridor at four in the morning and told a man his wife had died, and he did it so badly that he has never once been able to think about it on purpose.

The hospital installs something that reads better than he does. It does not take his job. It finds him another one, because the law wants a licensed human being to be the one who tells the patient. He turns out to be remarkable at it — at the silence, at not reaching for anything, at letting the worst hour of a stranger's life be exactly as bad as it is.

Four a day becomes nine. The figures the hospital keeps have never looked better, and the gratitude is not imagined.

What nobody can see, for most of a year, is that the hour he gives them comes out of him at par, and does not come back.

Nobody takes it from him. He hands it over an hour at a time, to people who will not remember his name, and at no point does anyone — himself least of all — think to write down what it came to.



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